

LATE BLOOMERS

Baby hunger is no longer a permanent affliction as urban Indian women, having put off motherhood for the right job or right man, turn to fertility treatments

■ By Purvi Malhotra

Doctors may say the biological clock is not a myth—90 per cent of the eggs in a woman degrade at the end of the critical 37th year—but motherhood delayed is no longer motherhood denied. From 42-year-old star director Farah Khan to 35-year-old graphic designer Ritika Lambha, a rising number of women are willing to admit that they took a little help to have their little bundle(s) of joy.

The pursuit of motherhood may not be easy but a mix of optimism and anxiety manages to make these late bloomers—a global celebrity stork club, whose most famous members are Emma Thompson, who turned to the treatment to conceive her daughter Gaia, born in 1999 when the Oscar-winner was 40, and *Friends*' star Courtney Cox-Arquette who had her baby at 41—stick to the course. Nothing deters them from fertility treatments. Not the fact that the treatment has only a 40 to 45 per cent chance of success, that there is a high risk of multiple babies (the possibility of twins is almost 25 per cent) and that there can be repeated trauma—ranging from hormonal imbalance to pain from multiple injections.

It's all worth it. Ask the baby bumpers' poster girl, the bouncy Khan, who began her pursuit immediately after marriage. Infertility wasn't an issue for her or her husband. "My cervix was smaller than normal, which made it impossible for me to conceive



▲ **BEJAL SHAN, 35, HOMEMAKER.** Gave birth to twins after a nine-year wait

TREATMENT Went through six IUI cycles. Her first IVF failed. She conceived in the second instance.

naturally," says an undaunted Khan. Her first stop was Mumbai baby doctor Furuza Parikh, director, Department of Assisted Reproduction and Genetics, Jaslok Hospital, who advised her to undergo intra-uterine insemination (IUI), which is done by placing the sperm in the uterus around the time of ovulation. The treatment, advised prior to the in-vitro fertilisation (IVF) treatment, failed in Khan's case. "Its failure was a nasty

shock," recalls Khan, blaming it on the stressful hours and commotion of shooting her blockbuster, *Om Shanti Om*. Her first IVF cycle began soon after the film's completion. "I went in for the treatment on June 7, and I was pregnant a month later," she says cheerily, the pain and nausea caused by the injections notwithstanding.

With more women conceiving their first child after 30—postponing it either because of career pressures or not finding the perfect man—the normal can become traumatic. Late blooming is becoming a nationwide trend. Geeta, consultant, foetal medicine at Fernandez Hospital in Hyderabad, says, "In the last five years, the number of women over 30 coming to us for their first concep-